



ALLIANCE FOR COLLECTIVE EMPOWERMENT AND DEVELOPMENT


PERSONAL & CONFIDENTIAL

Dear Mr. Martin,

My name is Leandre Poplus, founder of the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development, ACE. Before anything else, I want to say plainly that your body of work speaks for itself, four decades at the center of Black political journalism, a Peabody, the National Association of Black Journalists' Journalist of the Year, and a body of reporting that has reminded this country of what it too often prefers to look away from. That record is not in question here, and nothing that follows should be read as overlooking it.

Through every chapter of your career, one thing has remained unmistakable: Black media was never something you moved beyond. Your years on CNN and other mainstream platforms were never the destination, only a vehicle, while you built something permanent and independently owned the entire time. When TV One canceled your show, first in 2017 and again this past October, you evidently had an alternative standing that did not depend on either one.

Those actions are the proof behind what I want to say next: ***“A system built to exclude cannot be reformed into one that includes.”*** Every effort to integrate into institutions that were never built for us eventually meets the same ceiling you met twice: the platform can be taken from you at any time, because it was never truly yours to begin with. ACE starts from your own example and builds it out fully. Instead of asking to be kept on inside institutions that can cancel us whenever the budget shifts, ACE is a twenty-five-year plan to build the institutions themselves, housing, healthcare, education, governance, on sovereign land, owned and controlled from the start, for Black and Native American communities.

You have already answered the hardest part of this question for yourself. You built your real platform quietly, while the mainstream vehicle was still running, so that its cancellation would only ever be news, never a threat. That is precisely the posture ACE is built on: do not wait for the system to permit the real thing. Build it now, in parallel, so nothing it does later can take it from you.

At its best, Black media has distinguished itself by documenting the realities of a people continually forced to navigate the consequences of this country's political, economic, and social structures. Voter suppression. Persistent disparities in wealth. The enduring cost of survival itself. That reporting is indispensable; it has never been optional.

There is, though, another story Black media has rarely been given the opportunity to tell at scale: not simply how Black people endure existing conditions, but how they might deliberately construct



something beyond them. Not merely survival, but institution-building. Not simply resistance, but architecture.

ACE is the culmination of those ideals, a blueprint for making them real. Despite the magnitude of the mission, let me be candid: please do not mistake me for an activist, a politician, or a leader in the traditional sense. I do not ascribe to any of those roles.

I would describe myself as an advocate for the improvement, empowerment, and prosperity of Black people, and as someone who has thought critically about our people's past in an effort to help build a different future. What you have built for yourself over four decades is proof that the instinct is sound. I believe it deserves a larger stage than any one platform, mine or yours, can offer alone.

I am asking you to read this framework, challenge what should be challenged, and tell me plainly whether what you have built for yourself is buildable for all of us.

The founding volume is enclosed. I would welcome a serious conversation, on Unfiltered, on the Black Star Network, or simply directly, about what it would take to make this real.

Respectfully,

Leandre Poplus

Founder

Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development

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For Our People, By Our People

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